PSYCHOLOGICAL/COGNITIVE FALSE BELIEF #46 · ANXIETY

“If I don’t worry, I won’t be prepared.”

✦ ✦ ✦

Where it often comes from

Worry can masquerade as love or responsibility. A person who was surprised by hardship, or praised for always being prepared, may believe that worry is the work that keeps people safe. If they stop worrying, they feel guilty, as if they have stopped caring. Anxiety then calls itself a virtue. Planning is wise. Worry is the spinning that adds no hour to your life and no real protection to the people you love.

What Scripture teaches

Jesus asks who can add a single hour to life by worrying, and He says tomorrow can worry about itself. Paul says, “Be anxious for nothing,” and points to prayer with thanksgiving, and to peace that guards the heart. Trust leans on the Lord rather than on our own understanding. When anxiety overwhelms, God’s consolation is what delights the soul, not another lap of worry. Preparation can be a list, a phone call, a plan. Worry is not that list. It only feels like work.

> *“Be anxious for nothing, but in everything, by prayer and petition, with thanksgiving, present your requests to God. And the peace of God, which surpasses all understanding, will guard your hearts and your minds in Christ Jesus”* (Philippians 4:6–7).

Also see

> “Therefore do not worry about tomorrow, for tomorrow will worry about itself. Today has enough trouble of its own” (Matthew 6:34).

> “Who of you by worrying can add a single hour to his life?” (Matthew 6:27).

> “Trust in the LORD with all your heart, and lean not on your own understanding; in all your ways acknowledge Him, and He will make your paths straight” (Proverbs 3:5–6).

> “When anxiety overwhelms me, Your consolation delights my soul” (Psalm 94:19).

Common self-statements

- If I stop worrying, I am being careless.
- Somebody has to worry, and it is me.
- My worry is how I love people.
- The moment I feel calm, I have forgotten something.
- Planning is not enough. I have to feel the weight.
- God helps those who worry hard enough.

Common logical errors

- Emotional reasoning: Feeling guilty when you stop worrying, and calling the guilt proof you should worry.
- Magnification: Treating worry as if it were a useful safety tool.
- All-or-nothing thinking: Either I worry constantly or I am irresponsible.
- Fortune telling: Believing that calm today causes harm tomorrow.

Challenging questions

- What useful action is left, once I have already made a reasonable plan?
- Has an extra hour of worry ever prevented the thing I feared?
- Who told me that caring has to feel like dread?
- What would prayer do here that worry cannot?
- What is one worry I can turn into a task, and then set down?
- How would I want someone I love to carry a similar concern?

Truth summary

> Worry is not preparation. I can plan wisely and still hand the outcome to God.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

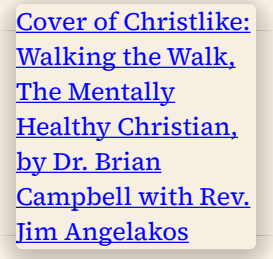
- Anxiety/Worry
- Thinking, Healthy
- Peace
- Trust
- Help

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Anxiety/Worry/Fear
- Thinking, Healthy
- Prayer

What does a mentally healthy Christian look like?



From *Christlike: Walking the Walk* by Dr. Brian Campbell. A portrait, verse by verse, of how a mentally healthy Christian thinks, feels, and lives.

Read excerpts from "The Mentally Healthy Christian" (with every Scripture written out)

Listen: Overcoming Anxiety

Overcoming Anxiety · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 18 minutes

Listen: Overcoming Depression

Overcoming Depression · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 20 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

Speak O Lord — Keith and Kristyn Getty
God's Word can shape your thoughts more truly than another hour of worry.

Thrive — Casting Crowns
A life with God is more than staying braced for trouble.

This Is Amazing Grace — Phil Wickham
You were not meant to carry every outcome by worrying.

How Great Thou Art — Jordan Smith
God is great enough that your worry is not what holds the world together.

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, what is one step I could take today?"

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "If I don't worry, I won't be prepared."

✦ ✦ ✦

Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"If I don't worry, I won't be prepared." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ What useful action is left, once I have already made a reasonable plan?
- ☐ Has an extra hour of worry ever prevented the thing I feared?
- ☐ Who told me that caring has to feel like dread?
- ☐ What would prayer do here that worry cannot?
- ☐ What is one worry I can turn into a task, and then set down?
- ☐ How would I want someone I love to carry a similar concern?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ Worry is not preparation. I can plan wisely and still hand the outcome to God.
- ☐ A plan is not the same thing as a worry spiral.
- ☐ Worry has not kept the people I love safe.
- ☐ I can care without rehearsing disaster.
- ☐ God invites me to pray instead of to spin.
- ☐ Peace is allowed while I am still responsible.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ Philippians 4:6–7
  "Be anxious for nothing, but in everything, by prayer and petition, with thanksgiving, present your requests to God. And the peace of God, which surpasses all understanding, will guard your hearts and your minds in Christ Jesus."
- ☐ Matthew 6:34
  "Therefore do not worry about tomorrow, for tomorrow will worry about itself. Today has enough trouble of its own."
- ☐ Matthew 6:27
  "Who of you by worrying can add a single hour to his life?"

A verse I found myself: _____

Practicing the Truth

✦ ✦ ✦

5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- [ ] Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- [ ] Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- [ ] Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- [ ] Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- [ ] When worry felt like love or duty: Each day, write down one moment when calm felt careless. Write what happened, what you told yourself, and one more accurate statement.
- [ ] My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.

  For example, Philippians 4:6 becomes: "Sarah can write: "I can bring this to God instead of worrying it into shape.""
- [ ] Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- [ ] Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- [ ] Reading: The "Anxiety/Worry" topic in Pearls.
- [ ] Listening: The Overcoming Anxiety audio or the Overcoming Depression audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

Choose steps you can do safely. If this belief comes with hopelessness or thoughts of ending your life, call or text 988 (the Suicide & Crisis Lifeline), or call 911 in an emergency. You do not have to carry this alone.

- [ ] Turn worry into a task or a prayer. If there is a real step, do it. If not, pray one sentence and close the subject.
- [ ] Time the spiral. Notice how long you worried and whether anything got safer. Write the result.
- [ ] Practice one calm hour after the useful plan is done. Do not reopen the worry during that hour.
- [ ] Tell a loved one you are learning that worry is not how you love them.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

_____

What I learned: _____

The lie “If I don’t worry, I won’t be prepared.”: _____ % My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	A worry I set down
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~If I don't worry, I won't be prepared~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Lord, I have called worry faithfulness. It has not made anyone safer. Teach me to plan what I can, pray what I cannot, and then rest. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.